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Monterey County Workers Vote to Authorize Unfair Labor Practice Strike by 97%, as Increased Vacancies, Rising Health Care Costs and Stagnant Wages Drive Public Sector Backlash

3,500+ SEIU 521 Represented Employees (in 9-1-1 Dispatch, Social Workers, Public Works, and Healthcare) voted 97% in favor of authorizing a strike to bring an end to Monterey County's Unfair Labor Practices compounded by a vacancy crisis, stagnant wages and rising healthcare costs.

Monterey County, CA–Over 3,500 essential workers across Monterey County united in a powerful show of unity, approving a crucial strike authorization vote that will reshape their futures. Once hailed as heroes for their efforts during the pandemic but now largely ignored by management, these dedicated workers are demanding the respect and fair treatment they deserve.

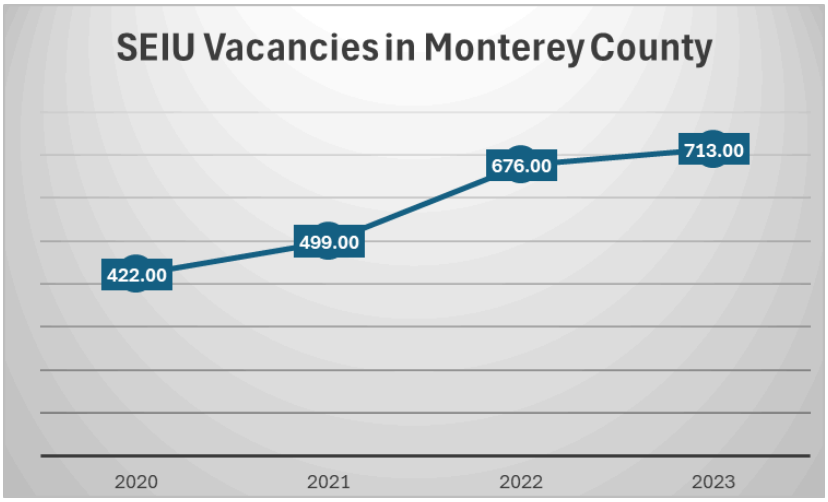
The county-wide vote is the culmination of months of determined worksite protests, rallies, and relentless lobbying efforts focused on resolving the vacancy crisis exploding in Monterey County public service agencies. The message is clear: workers will no longer tolerate the vacancy crisis caused by non-competitive wages and unaffordable healthcare.

"Despite our repeated proposals to address these issues, the County is pushing outrageous increases to healthcare costs and embattling the vacancy crisis. The crisis is undermining every aspect of care and service—from public safety and child protective services to behavioral health support and road maintenance, and the County makes all aspects of this worse with their behavior" said ***Harriet Stevens, SEIU Monterey County Chapter President. "***

Vacancy Crisis in Monterey County – How Did We Get here?

At the heart of this conflict lies unilateral, unauthorized changes by the county who:

- Deliberately understaffed agencies through a discriminatory hiring process
- Unilaterally increased hours for workers in the Inmate Service Specialist classification by assigning workers in the unit to redo housing units, outside of their job duties. These changes caused the workers to suffer potential lead exposure.
- Unilaterally set new standards for Social Workers III, IV, and V which included an increase in caseload volumes and changes to the disciplinary process.



County Management's Unfair Labor Practices the Center of the Worker's Struggles

"County workers are the backbone of our community's well-being," said SEIU 521 member ***Araceli Flores, Psychiatric Social Worker II****. "We deserve a contract that acknowledges our sacrifices and provides resources needed to continue delivering exceptional care. Instead, the County's position which forces unaffordable health insurance costs, the impact is pushing us toward a strike—a measure we take seriously, a measure of last resort."*

County Department	Percentage Vacant
Health and Clinics Department	22.26%
Social Services	12.86%
Public Works Facilities and Parks	17.30%
Emergency Communications	17.33%
Housing & Community Development	12.62%
Library	18.05%
Treasurer/Tax Collector	12.24%

A Call for Fairness and Responsibility

Union leadership remains committed to negotiating a deal that includes responsible solutions to retain workers ensuring the necessary support to keep county services running. *“Monterey County has the opportunity to be a model employer—one that values its workers and the critical services they provide. Yet, management’s intransigence makes a strike increasingly likely,”* Stevens added.

The current contract between SEIU 521 and the County expired on July 1, 2024. The union represents workers across a wide range of vital public services, including public safety, healthcare, social services, mental and behavioral health, road maintenance, and parks.

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Service Employees International Union, Local 521 represents more than 3,500 public-sector workers across Monterey County. Under a Community First vision, we are committed to making sure the needs of our community, and the vital services we provide our community, come first. We believe our communities thrive when residents, leaders, and workers recognize that we are all in this together when it comes to our safety, health, and well-being.